

awkward situations for parents and teachers with children describing their status as single or in relationship. "Be happy, she is single again," a 12-year-old boy wrote on Facebook about a girl who happened to be his friend's crush. "She is my crush," 11-year-old Neil told his parents. "Girlfriend," joked his parents. "No. A girlfriend is someone you are committed to, a crush is merely a strong liking," he retorted. Linguistic distinctions are important. They form

Hit the Panic Button if...

1. Your child becomes excessively secretive. Everything he or she does appears to be an undercover operation.
2. The history page on your computer is always clear. This means your child is smarter than you thought and has been deleting all accounts of the sites he or she has visited
3. He or she grabs the remote control as soon as you enter the room. They have been watching something you do not want them to.
4. Too much time and money is being spent on grooming products.
5. Their grades have suddenly fallen from A to F.
6. You are getting complaints from other children's parents about how your child has been a bad influence on theirs.
7. Suddenly they don't want to go out shopping with you because it's uncool.
8. They begin to take a few decisions by themselves like the clothes they want to wear or the kind of diet they want to follow.

Trust the Tweens

1. Be a friend to them. Show them your trust and they will trust you.

2. Educate them before they learn a few things the wrong way. This way they will keep coming to you for advice.

3. Give them a fair amount of freedom. Restricting them completely might lead to rebellious behaviour.

4. Don't be impatient. They are vulnerable

and volatile. Deal with them with maturity.

5. Talk to them of your childhood. It will make them realise that you have been through the same age.

6. Do not, at any point, let them undermine your authority. You are still the parent.

7. Be interested in their life but don't be overbearing. This will make them retreat into a shell.



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a secret code that binds them, that identifies them, allowing them to either LOL (laugh out loud) or ROFL (roll on the floor laughing), that allows them to sound the alert (MOS means mom over the shoulder), or make a request (CICYHW means can I copy your home work), or even bare their hearts (MUSM means miss you so much).

But an increasing number of tweens are now seeking counselling. "Earlier I had a few 18-year-olds seeking counselling but now even 10-year-olds are being brought in by their parents. The number has risen by 75 per cent in the past two years," says Mumbai-based psychologist Seema Hingorani. She gets reg-

ular e-mails from 11-year-olds for problems ranging from relationships, anger towards parents to money. "Parents are too authoritarian in their approach. The rigidity must go. One cannot expect the children to replicate the way they behaved when they were young. Society is changing," says educationist Namita Ranganathan from Delhi.

But with parents confused in their approach about whether they should be permissive or authoritarian, schools barely equipped to handle the academic load and society at large commodifying pre-teens, the wonder years are on the way to becoming the what-now years.

with Kruttika Kallury and Arvind Chhabra